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Cosmetics

10.6 Cosmetics

Oil: See 1.10.5 Anointing oil<REALIA:1.10.5>; 1.15.1 Oil, ointment<REALIA:1.15.1>; 9.3 Olive oil<REALIA:9.3>.

Perfumes

10.6.1 Perfumes

References:

Hebrew מִרְקַחַת, רִקָּח, רֹקַח, רַקָּח, רָקַח, רקח (raqach (verb), reqach, roqach, riquach, mirqachath) EXO 30:25, EXO 30:25, EXO 30:25, EXO 30:35, EXO 30:35, EXO 37:29, 1SA 8:13, 1CH 9:30, 1CH 9:30, 2CH 16:14, 2CH 16:14, NEH 3:8, ECC 10:1, SNG 8:2, ISA 57:9

Hebrew שֶׁמֶן (shemen) 2SA 14:2, PRO 27:9, ECC 7:1, ECC 9:8, ECC 10:1, SNG 1:3, SNG 1:3, SNG 4:10, ISA 57:9, ISA 61:3, EZK 16:9, MIC 6:15

Greek ἤδυσμα (ēdusma) ESG 4:17

Description:

Perfumes were specially produced mixtures of pleasant-smelling spices usually added to an oil base. They were used to cover unpleasant smells such as human perspiration, decaying bodies, or even the bloody results of ritual slaughter.

Translation:

The Hebrew verb raqach means “to mix, compound,” while the Hebrew word shemen means “oil.”

Myrrh

10.6.1.1 Myrrh

References:

Hebrew לֹט (lot) GEN 37:25, GEN 43:11

Hebrew מֹר (mor) EXO 30:23, EST 2:12, PSA 45:9, PRO 7:17, SNG 1:13, SNG 3:6, SNG 4:6, SNG 4:14, SNG 5:1, SNG 5:5, SNG 5:5, SNG 5:13

Greek μυροβρεχής (murobrechēs) 3MA 4:6

Greek μύρον (muron) MAT 26:7, MAT 26:12, MRK 14:3, MRK 14:4, LUK 7:38, LUK 7:46, JHN 11:2, JHN 12:3, JHN 12:3, JHN 12:5, REV 18:13, JDT 10:3, WIS 2:7

Greek σμύρνα, σμυρνίζω (smurna, smurnizō (verb)) MAT 2:11, MRK 15:23, SIR 24:15

Description and usage:

Myrrh was the aromatic resin of certain bushes. This resin was added to an oil base to make a perfume to put on the body. See also 4.8.3.1 Embalming oils<REALIA:4.8.3.1>.

Translation:

The tree that produced the myrrh resin was not native to Israel, and the import of myrrh made it an expensive luxury. This should be borne in mind when translating EST 2:12; PSA 45:9; PRO 7:17; SNG 1:13; MAT 2:11.

Most translators borrow a term for “myrrh.” In some passages translators may expand the translation to indicate the nature of the substance; compare GNT at PSA 45:9, where it says “perfume of myrrh.” In many instances, particularly in the New Testament, they may use a general expression such as “ointment,” “aromatic oil,” or “perfume.” When the Greek word muron means “perfume,” it may be rendered “sweet-smelling oil” or “fragrant oil.”

Oil of nard

10.6.1.2 Oil of nard

References:

Hebrew נֵרְדְּ (nerd) SNG 1:12, SNG 4:13, SNG 4:14

Greek νάρδος (nardos) MRK 14:3, JHN 12:3

Description:

Oil of nard was an aromatic oil extracted from a plant called nard.

Translation:

Translators normally borrow the term “nard” but use some type of classifier, for example, “perfume called nard” or “sweet-smelling substance, nard.” For other issues related to the above verses, see also 5.18.1.3 Alabaster jar, alabaster flask<REALIA:5.18.1.3>.